was there in the evening when I woke up, dozing by my side. Chimpu was asleep on his lap. As I struggled to get up, I felt an unbearable pain shoot up my knee when I tried to fold my leg. ‘Don’t move the leg, beta,’ Papaji woke up and said. He helped me sit. ‘Now tell me, how did this happen?’ he asked as he stroked my head. ‘I tripped and fell.’ Knowing I was lying to him, I averted my eyes.

‘That story is for others, not me. So, tell me what happened, Gunju. It’s okay,’ he asked again. I looked into his eyes and narrated everything that had happened. ‘Dada knows too. He will take care of that boy,’ I concluded.

Papaji took a deep breath, held my hand in his and said, ‘It is not Dada’s fight. It is your fight, Gunju.’

I looked at him with confusion on my face. ‘Look, what happened to you was bad, right?’ he asked, and I nodded. ‘Was it unjust?’ he asked. I nodded as I listened to him. ‘Was Dada there to protect you?’ he asked.

‘No,’ I replied, unhappily.

‘When you grow up to be a big girl, there will be many more fights. Anshu loves you a lot, but he might not always be there to protect you,’ he said.

‘But where will Dada go?’ I threw an innocent question at him.

‘Well, let’s just say, Anshu goes to college or gets a job in a different city. What then?’ Papaji asked, to which I had no answer. I dropped my shoulders and looked down. ‘Learn to fight your own fights, Gunju,’ Papaji gently lifted my chin with his finger. ‘Make yourself so strong that nobody picks a fight with you. They just won’t if they know that this girl will fight back,’ Papaji spoke softly, yet firmly. I listened.

‘But those boys were big boys,’ I said.

‘No matter how big your problem is, you should face it. If you cannot face it with strength, then apply your mind,’ Papaji pressed his index finger to my forehead. ‘The mind always wins over muscle. Now when you go to school after your knee gets better, *make yourself heard*. Let them know they cannot mess with my little girl. Finish every fight anyone picks with you. All you need to do is devise a strategy.’ He then looked at my knee and